

The Knicks' Best Finals Path in Years

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Executive Summary

Coming into the season, expectations were higher than they had been in years for the New York Knicks. With a deep collection of offensive talent, two game-changing defenders in Mitchell Robinson and OG Anunoby, and Mike Brown taking over on the sideline, the question around New York became pretty simple: if not now, when?

The East has opened up. Boston is already out. Indiana is not the same obstacle it was a year ago. Cleveland and Detroit still pose challenges, but New York is now two wins away from the conference finals after closing the door on Atlanta and taking control against Philadelphia. The Knicks are playing like a team that knows this is their chance. This has not been the old playoff formula, where Brunson had to carry every late-clock possession and drag the offense home. He is still the organizer and tone-setter, but he has not had to do it alone.

That is where Towns and Anunoby have impacted the run in a major way. KAT has given New York a second star who can score, pass, draw fouls, and hold up defensively better than expected. OG has been the cleanest swing piece on the roster, defending across matchups while scoring more efficiently than anyone could have reasonably expected.

Through eight playoff games, the Knicks look as poised as any team in the East to make a Finals push. The numbers back it up: elite offense, high-level defense, and more than one player capable of swaying a game individually.

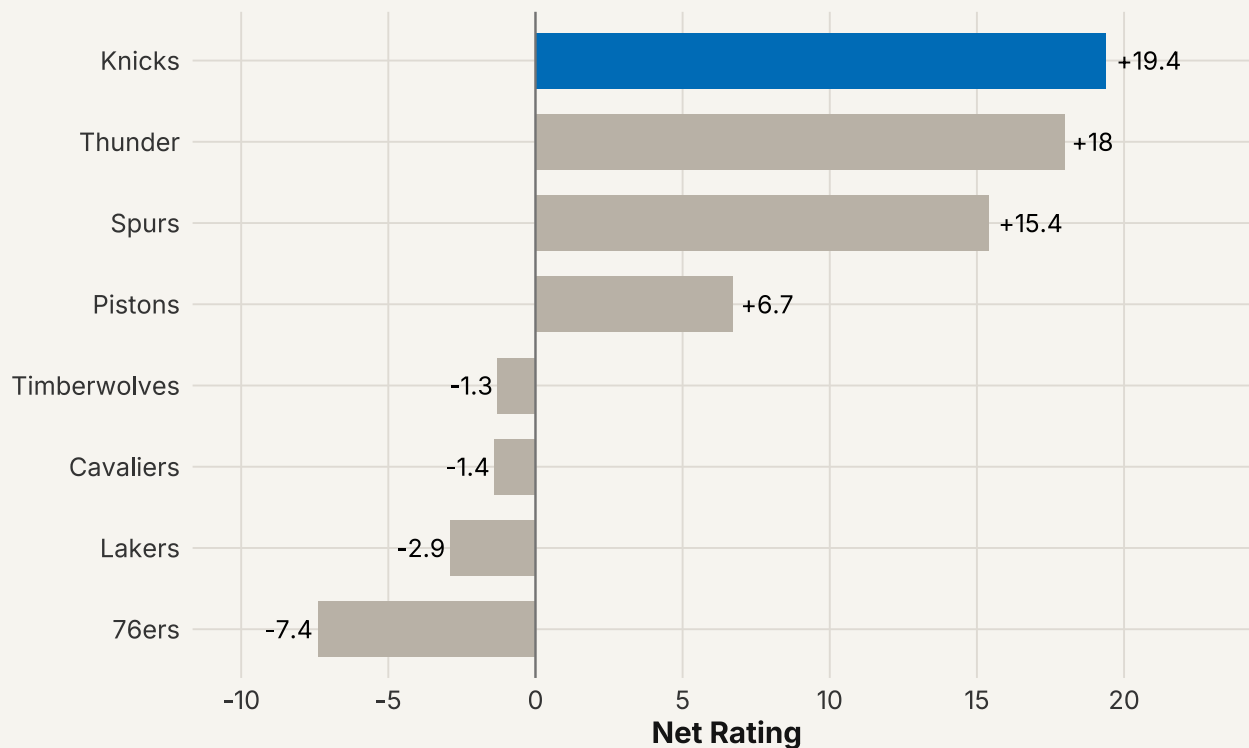
Where The Knicks Stand

Table 1: Remaining playoff teams by overall profile

Team	W-L	OffRtg	DefRtg	NetRtg	TS%	TOV%	OREB%	Pace
New York Knicks	6-2	123.2	103.8	19.4	62.4%	13.8%	32.3%	96.6
Oklahoma City Thunder	6-0	125.5	107.5	18.0	62.1%	12.7%	34.2%	96.1
San Antonio Spurs	5-2	116.0	100.6	15.4	59.3%	15.4%	30.1%	98.7
Detroit Pistons	6-3	109.7	103.0	6.7	55.4%	16.4%	33%	94.9
Minnesota Timberwolves	5-3	108.6	109.9	-1.3	54.6%	14.5%	31.4%	100.2
Cleveland Cavaliers	4-5	111.7	113.2	-1.4	57.5%	17.3%	34.9%	96.2
Los Angeles Lakers	4-4	106.5	109.4	-2.9	57.1%	19.2%	31.3%	93.1
Philadelphia 76ers	4-5	109.2	116.6	-7.4	55.6%	13.2%	25.6%	94.3

New York is in good company

The Knicks, Thunder, and Spurs have separated from the remaining field



Data: NBA.com | Viz: @Rambzee_

Figure 1: Net Rating among remaining playoff teams

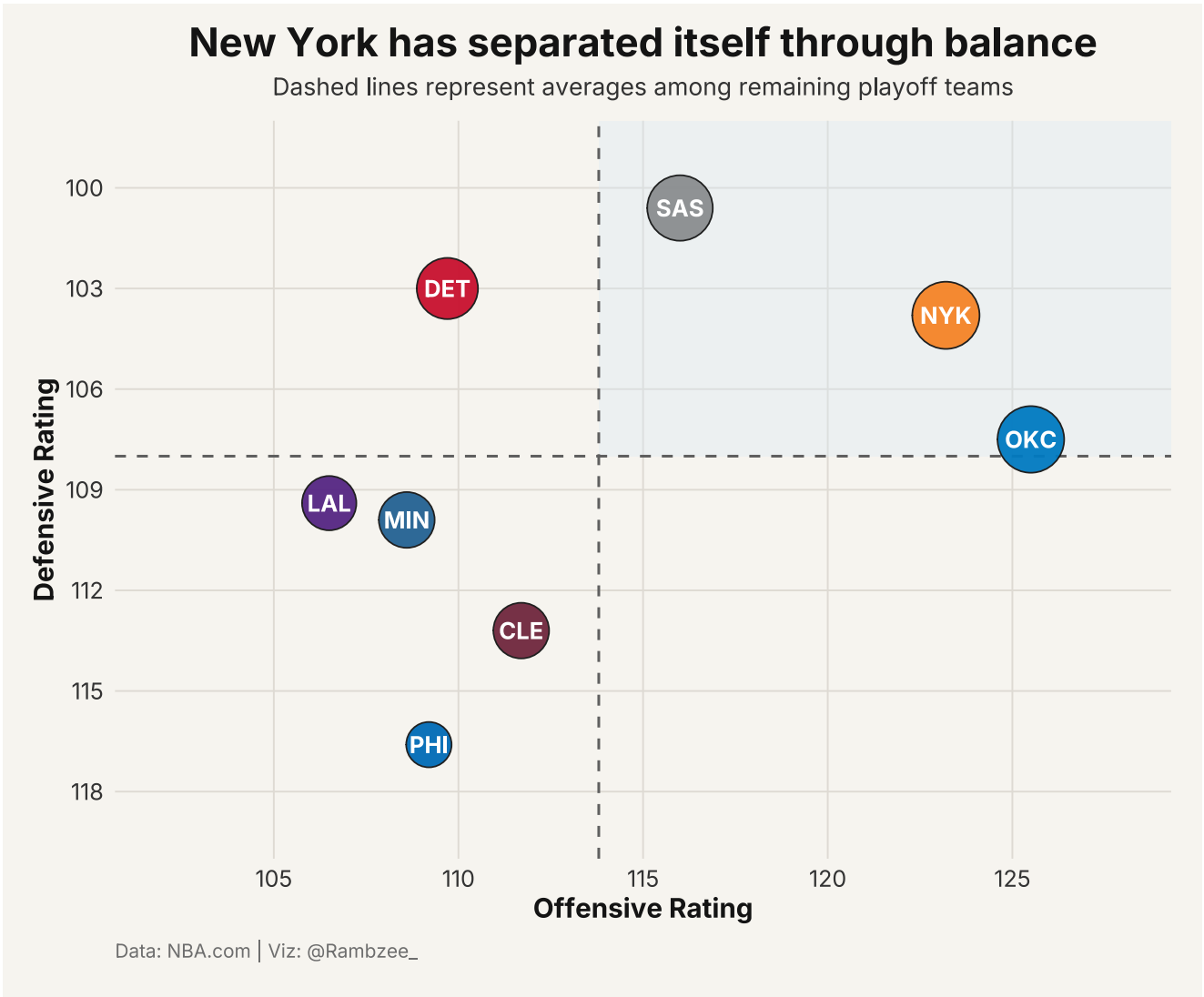


Figure 2: Offensive and defensive balance among remaining playoff teams

The Knicks have not just been good by East standards. Among the remaining teams, they combine the best Net Rating with an elite offense and a defense that has been strong enough to keep games from becoming pure shotmaking contests.

The Knicks Have Become More Interconnected

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Table 2: Combined playoff production from Brunson, Towns, and Anunoby

PPG	RPG	APG	Avg TS%	Total +/-
67.4	20.1	13.2	70%	+43.2

The team-level leap starts with the Knicks’ top three. Through eight playoff games, Brunson, Towns, and Anunoby have combined for 67.4 points, 20.1 rebounds, and 13.2 assists per game. Brunson is still the first name on the scouting report, but the burden is spread more cleanly than in past playoff runs.

Karl-Anthony Towns: More Than a Scoring Big

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Table 3: Karl-Anthony Towns regular-season and playoff split comparison

Window	PTS	AST	REB	BLK	TS%	2P%	3P%	FTA	FTr	TOV	+/-
First 76 Games	20.0	3.0	11.8	0.5	61.9%	55.7%	36.9%	5.5	40%	2.5	+5
Last 8 Games	18.6	6.1	10.5	1.5	75.3%	64.2%	50%	6.3	64.9%	3.1	+13.6

KAT's playoff run has been predicated on the poise and control he has given the Knicks. His assists have doubled from 3.0 to 6.1 per game, his free-throw attempts are up, his FTr has jumped from 40.0% to 64.9%, his blocks have climbed from 0.5 to 1.5 per game, and his efficiency has exploded to 75.3% true shooting.

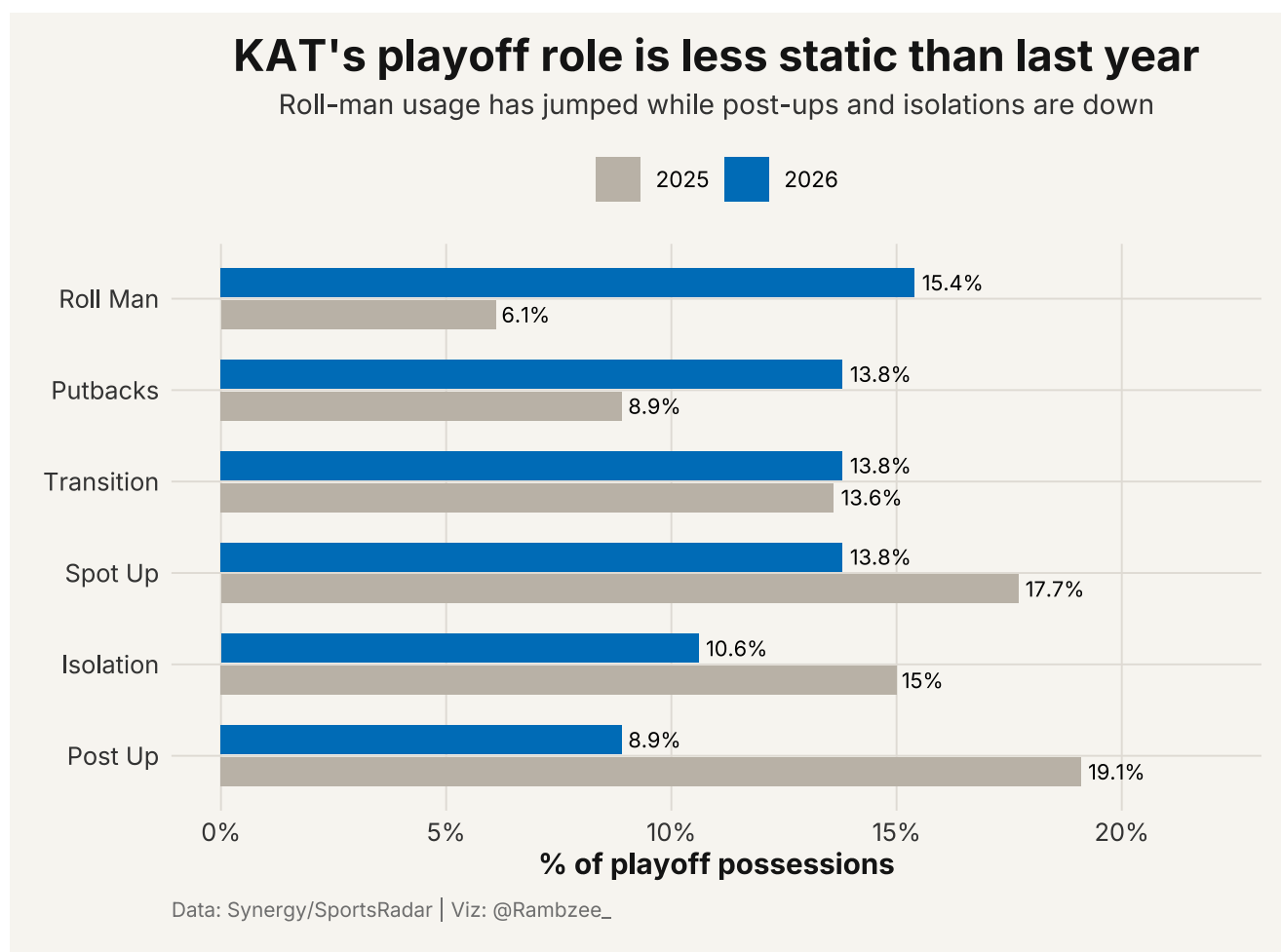


Figure 3: KAT playoff playtype distribution change

The playtype shift helps explain why. Compared with last year's playoff run, KAT is spending far less time in static post-ups and isolations and more time creating pressure as a roller, transition threat, and cleanup scorer. He is not just catching the ball and trying to score over a set defense. He is catching on the move, using his size near the rim, drawing help, and making the next pass when the defense reacts.

That version of KAT is more useful, even if the scoring average is slightly lower. He looks more in control and more physically imposing because his scoring, passing, foul pressure, and size are all working together.

KAT's Defense Deserves Its Own Note

Table 4: Knicks playoff WOWY lineup splits with KAT and Mitchell Robinson

Lineup	MIN	OFF	DEF	NET	NYK 3P%	OPP 3P%
Towns ON, Robinson OFF	223	125.6	103.2	+22.5	40.1%	33.5%
Robinson ON, Towns OFF	79	122.7	104.5	+18.2	33.3%	24.6%
Towns OFF, Robinson OFF	66	122.7	111.2	+11.5	38.3%	36.6%
Towns ON, Robinson ON	16	127.3	103.0	+24.2	42.9%	40%

The jump in blocks suggests that KAT's added control has not only shown up on offense. The defensive piece still deserves some caution, but the early signs are strong. In the playoffs, the Knicks have defended at a 103.2 Defensive Rating in 223 minutes with Towns on and Robinson off, which shows his value has not depended on playing next to another strong rim protector.

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Table 5: Knicks playoff performance with Towns on and off the floor

Lineup	MIN	OffRtg	DefRtg	NetRtg	3P%	Opp 3P%
Towns ON	239	+125.7	+103.1	+22.6	40.3%	33.9%
Towns OFF	145	+122.7	+107.6	+15.1	35.7%	29.2%
ON - OFF	—	+3	-4.5	+7.5	4.6%	4.7%

The Towns-only on/off does not need to be oversold, but it supports the broader point. New York has been strong with him on and off the floor, which says as much about the team as it does about Towns. Still, the Knicks have been better in his minutes: +22.6 Net Rating with him on compared to +15.1 with him off, driven by gains on both ends.

The more useful takeaway is not that Towns alone has carried the defense. It is that his minutes have not been something New York has had to protect. For a player whose playoff defense has often been questioned, that is a meaningful step.

OG is the Perfect Role Player

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Table 6: OG Anunoby regular-season and playoff split comparison

Window	PTS	AST	REB	BLK	TS%	2P%	3P%	FTA	FTr	TOV	+/-
First 68 Games	16.9	2.2	5.3	0.7	62.3%	58.7%	38.8%	3.3	27.5%	1.8	+6
Last 8 Games	21.4	1.3	7.5	1.1	75.5%	67.2%	53.8%	4.6	38.1%	0.5	+14.8

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Table 7: How the Knicks' top three have changed in the playoffs

Player	PTS change	AST change	REB change	TS% change	FTA change	TOV change	+/- change
OG Anunoby	+4.5	-0.9	+2.2	+13.2 pp	+1.3	-1.3	+8.8

OG's jump is the cleanest individual playoff swing on the roster. The scoring has climbed, but the more important part is how cleanly it has come. Going from 16.9 to 21.4 points while jumping to 75.5% true shooting is not normal role-player variance. He has been New York's second-leading scorer, and he has done it while cutting his turnovers from 1.8 to 0.5 per game.

Offensively, he has been a flamethrower. When Brunson or Towns bends the defense, OG has punished the gap, the late rotation, or the clean catch-and-shoot chance. And that scoring leap has not come at the expense of his

normal defensive workload. He has still been everywhere, taking turns on Jalen Johnson, CJ McCollum, Tyrese Maxey, VJ Edgecombe, and Paul George.

The injury after Game 2 against Philadelphia complicates the short-term picture, but it does not erase what he has meant to this run. New York has put itself in position to buy him time, and if he can return later in the playoffs, OG still has a chance to be one of the biggest reasons behind a Knicks Finals appearance.

Brunson Does Not Have to Carry Every Possession

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Table 8: Jalen Brunson regular-season and playoff split comparison

Window	PTS	AST	REB	BLK	TS%	2P%	3P%	FTA	FT%	TOV	+/-
First 75 Games	26.0	6.8	3.3	0.1	57.8%	52%	36.8%	5.7	28.3%	2.4	+4.7
Last 8 Games	27.4	5.8	2.1	0.0	59.2%	53%	37.5%	6.3	30.7%	2.4	+14.8

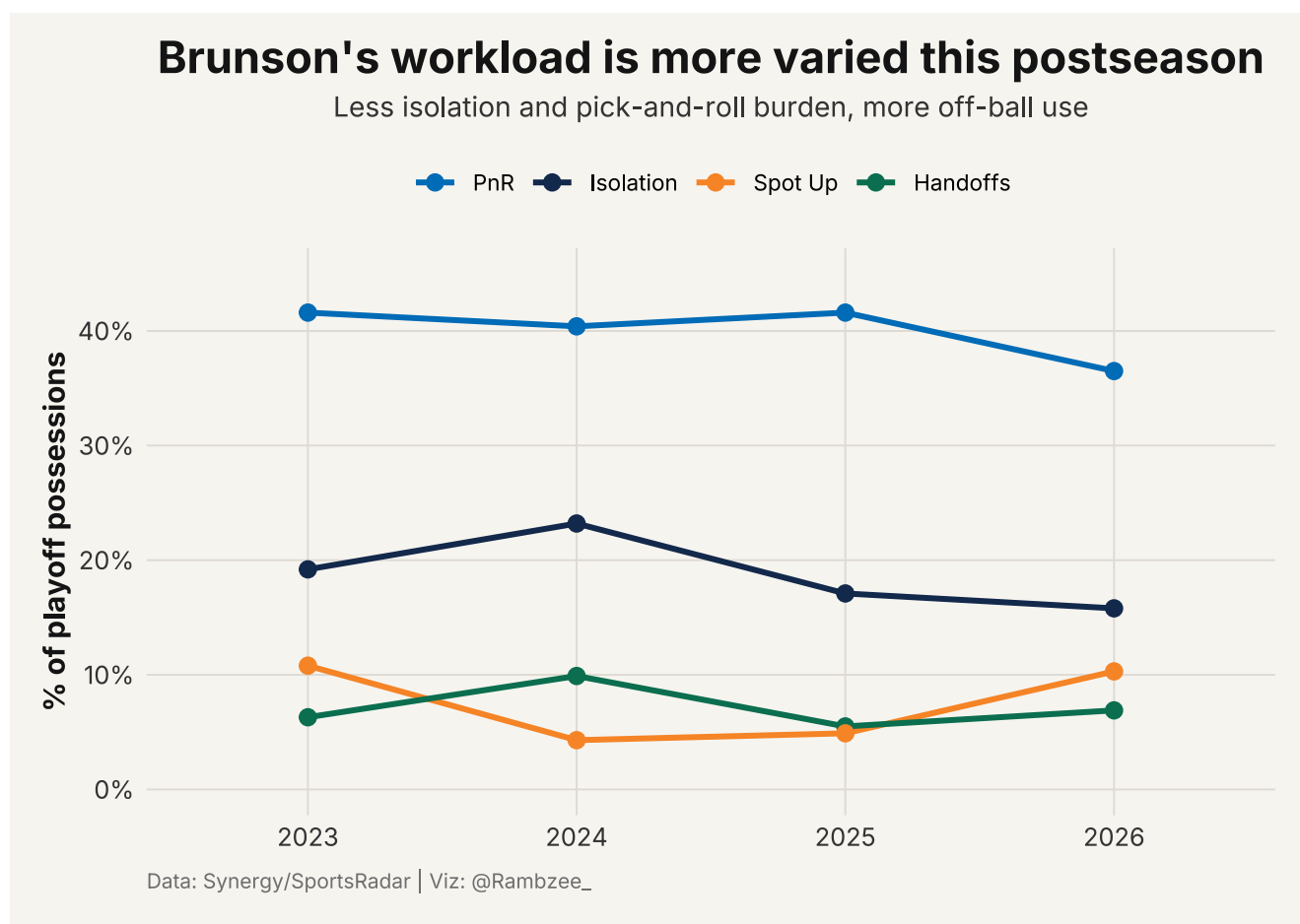


Figure 4: Jalen Brunson playoff playtype distribution

Brunson is still the engine of the offense. The difference is that New York is no longer asking him to create every advantage himself. His pick-and-roll share remains high, but it has fallen from the 40-42% range of previous playoff runs to 36.5% this postseason. His isolation share is also down, while his spot-up usage has climbed back above 10%. KAT's playmaking and OG's finishing have allowed the Knicks to involve him in more varied actions instead of forcing him to hold the ball and save every possession.

Despite the shift in offensive usage, Brunson is still averaging 27.4 points per game on strong efficiency. The

difference is that the offense no longer feels as dependent on him surviving impossible possessions over and over again.

Where There's Still Questions

Mikal Bridges

Table 9: Mikal Bridges' playoff reset

Window	Games	PPG	TS%	2P%	3P%	FTA	TOV	+/-
Games 1-5	5	7.2	53.3%	43.8%	26.7%	0.8	1.2	-2.2
Games 6-8	3	19.7	82.2%	80.8%	55.6%	0.7	0.0	+22

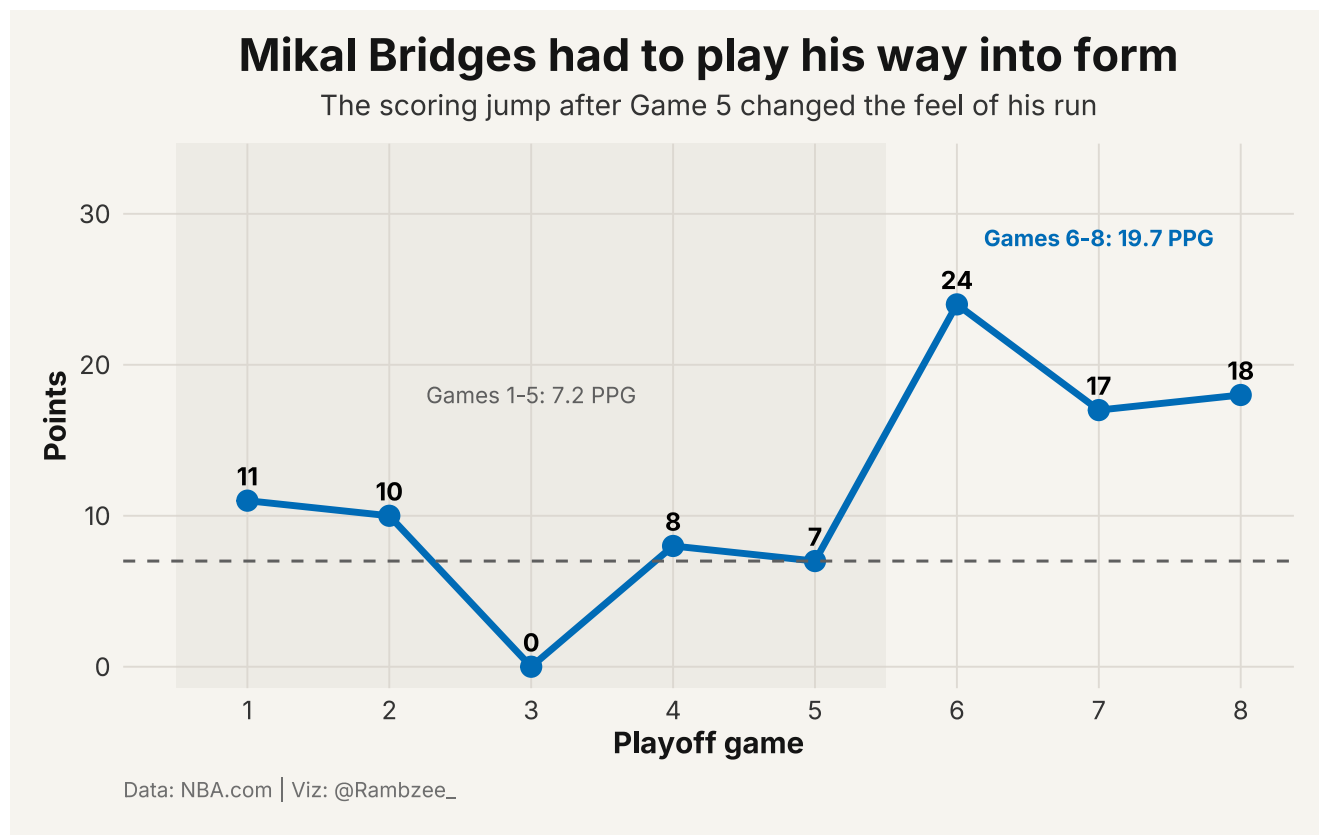


Figure 5: Mikal Bridges game-by-game playoff scoring progression

Bridges is the biggest variable left in the rotation. The last three games have been excellent, but the opening five still matter. Against Atlanta, the passivity, settling, and uneven pressure all showed up.

The recent jump is encouraging. He looks more comfortable, more involved, and more willing to punish space. The concern is that a lot of the surge is still jumper-reliant. When the shot is falling, he looks like the missing piece. When it is not, the Knicks still need him to find ways to impact the game without drifting.

New York does not need Bridges to be a third star every night. But it does need the Games 6-8 version far more than the Games 1-5 version.

Josh Hart

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Table 10: Josh Hart regular-season and playoff split comparison

Window	PTS	AST	REB	STL	TS%	2P%	3P%	FTA	TOV	+/-
First 67 Games	12.0	4.8	7.4	1.1	61.4%	57.9%	41.2%	1.9	1.9	+3.1
Last 8 Games	9.3	4.8	8.8	1.8	48.4%	53.8%	23.3%	2.1	1.9	+13.8

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Table 11: Josh Hart playoff Net Points profile

Player	G	Offensive Net Points	Defensive Net Points	Overall Net Points
Josh Hart	8	-14	+14	0

Hart has mostly been the same player he was during the regular season, for better and worse. The defensive activity, rebounding, and general chaos have still been there, which is why his defensive Net Points impact has remained strong even while the offense has slipped.

The concern is the scoring efficiency. Hart's scoring, true shooting, and three-point efficiency have all dropped in the playoffs, and unlike Bridges, there has not really been a breakout stretch yet to offset it. The Knicks can survive some offensive limitations because of everything else he provides, but the current version leaves clear room for improvement.

Net Points: Who Has Impacted Most?

Net Points Definition: Net Points is a play-by-play based metric that assigns credit and blame for every possession while a player is on the floor, capturing scoring, turnovers, defense, and context beyond the box score. It reflects how much a player actually moved the score, not just what they produced individually.

Table 12: Knicks playoff Net Points, minimum seven games

Player	G	Offense	Defense	Overall
Karl-Anthony Towns	8	+28	+20	+48
OG Anunoby	8	+29	+13	+42
Jalen Brunson	8	+29	+8	+38
Mikal Bridges	8	+6	+3	+9
Jose Alvarado	7	+3	+6	+9
Mitchell Robinson	7	+1	+3	+5
Jordan Clarkson	8	0	+3	+4
Miles McBride	8	-10	+10	0
Josh Hart	8	-14	+14	0
Landry Shamet	8	-9	-1	-10

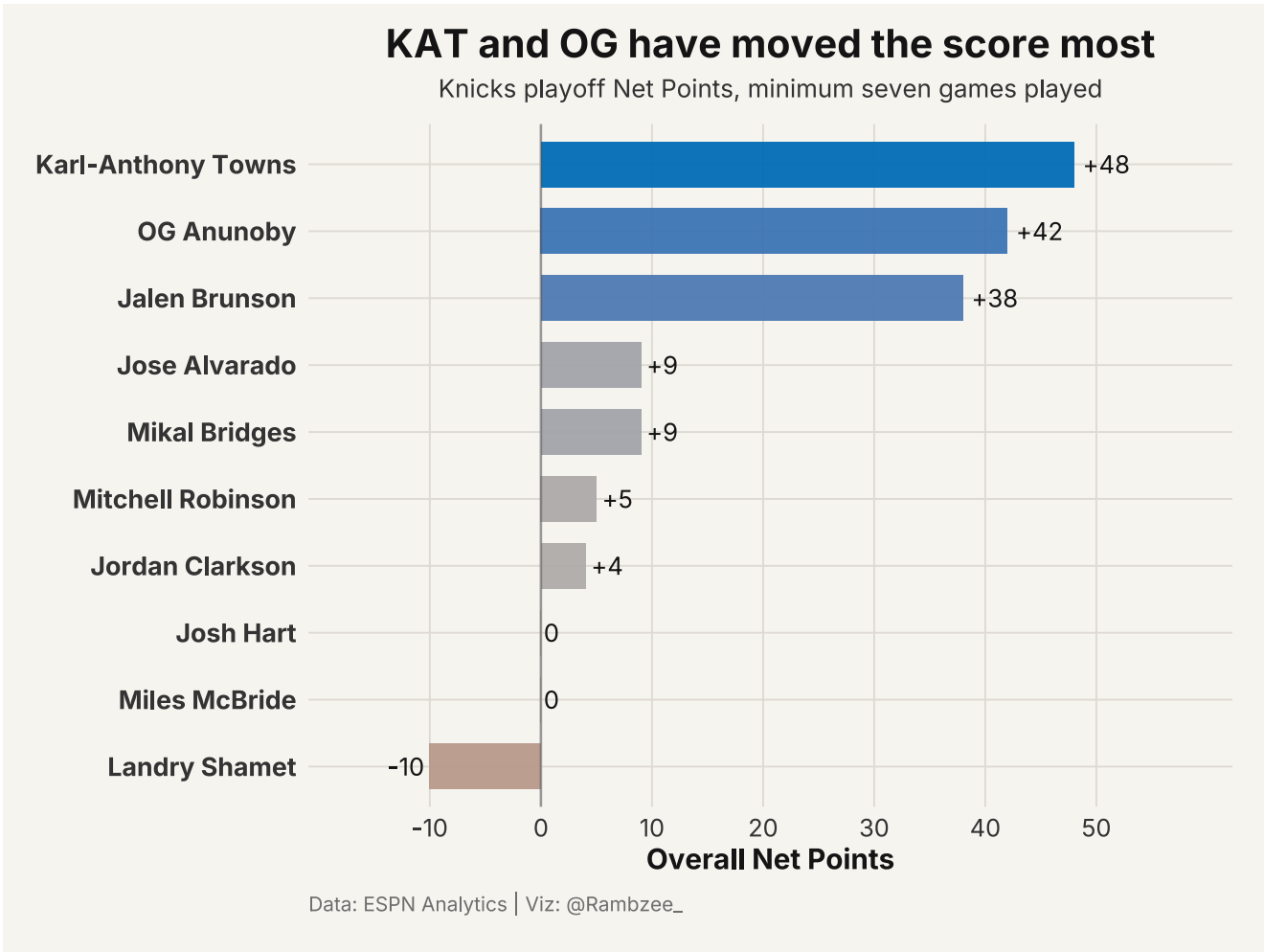


Figure 6: Knicks playoff Net Points by player

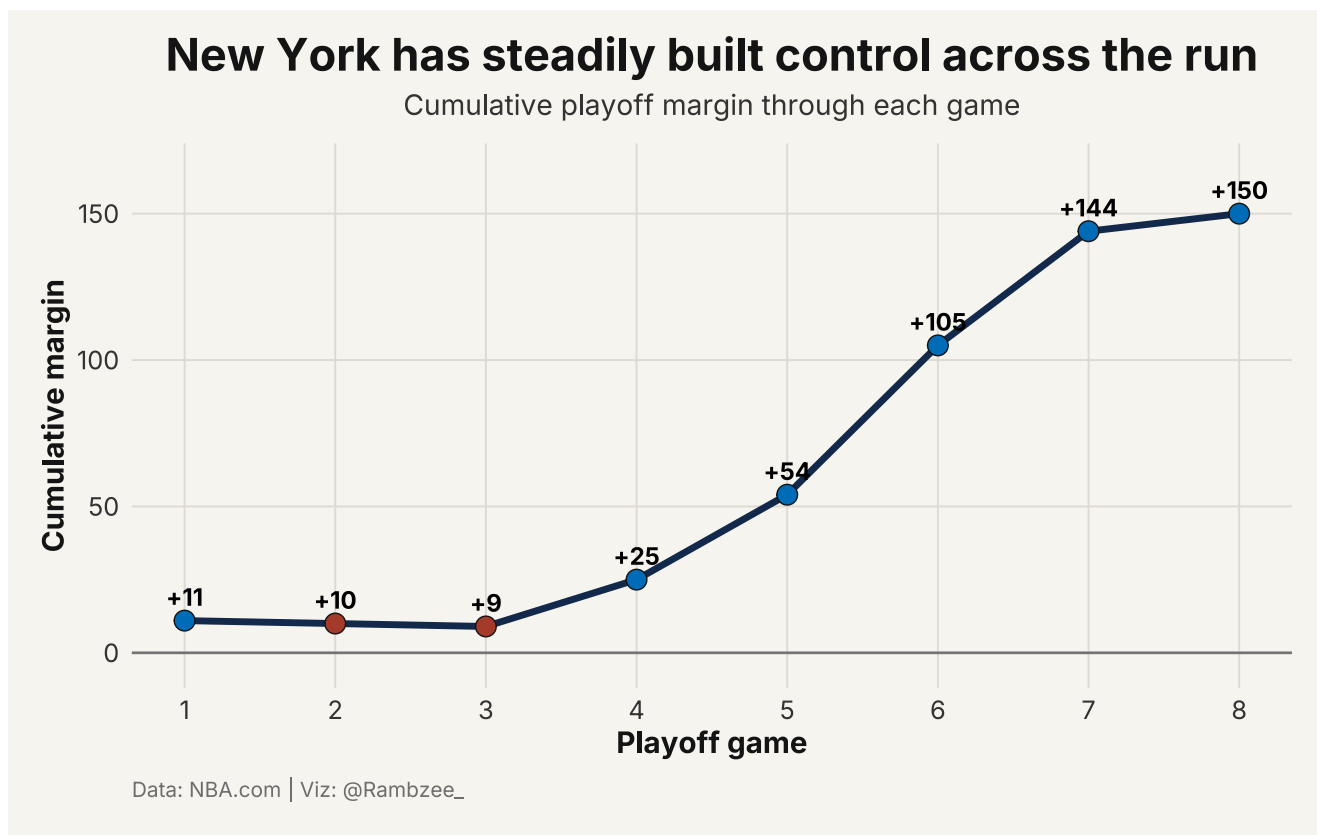


Figure 7: Knicks playoff cumulative margin over time

The broader picture is still encouraging. New York’s best players have moved the score the most, and the team has steadily built control instead of scraping by on late-game variance. KAT, OG, and Brunson sit clearly at the top of the Net Points leaderboard, while the cumulative margin shows how sharply the Knicks separated after the first three games.

That does not mean the rest of the run is clean. OG’s health matters, and his absence is significant for a team trying to maintain its level and reach its ceiling. Bridges needs to keep trending toward the Games 6-8 version. Hart has to find enough offense to match the defensive value he still provides. But the foundation is there: the Knicks have defended, created multiple areas of margin, and won their minutes like a team with a legitimate path forward.

Conclusion

The Knicks do not need every number to hold exactly where it is. OG will not shoot 75.5% true shooting forever. Mikal’s last-three-game surge still needs a larger sample. KAT’s efficiency will be tested as defenses adjust and the matchups get bigger, stronger, and more physical. Brunson will see better perimeter defenses the deeper this run goes.

Even with those concerns, New York’s playoff formula looks more complete than it has in years. They can win through Brunson, through Towns, through defense, through pressure, or through the margins. The stars have carried the top of the roster, the role players have given them enough, and the team-level dominance has only raised the standard.

With that opportunity comes pressure. This is not just a nice “Knicks are back” story anymore. It is their clearest chance to win the East.